example, had remained reticent even as then Vice President Johnson had hoped he would publicly criticize the communist approach in South Vietnam.[179] American and British officials, however, had been pleasantly surprised by Nehru's nonhostile reaction to an increased US presence in South Vietnam in late 1961 and his government's cautious and balanced approach in the International Control Commission (where it was the neutral member) after the buildup—despite objections by some within the Indian government.

At the International Control Commission in 1962, India had taken a stance on North Vietnamese involvement in South Vietnam that the Canadian representative had interpreted as "a turning point in Indian foreign policy in [the] direction of greatly increased firmness in dealing with the communist bloc." This stance was later seen as the reason that North Vietnam jettisoned its neutral position on the Sino-Indian dispute in favor of a pro-Chinese one. Despite Western fears that India would soon tilt the other way to display its neutrality, India had subsequently supported a policy of "masterly inactivity" for the International Control Commission—an approach that British officials had noted favored the West.[180] Following that, Indian officials had repeatedly told their American counterparts that they did not want the US to withdraw from Vietnam, not just in the Kennedy administration but also in the early Johnson years. As Mark Lawrence has noted, Indian officials acknowledged American "efforts to keep communists out of Southeast Asia, and … hoped that this effort would be successful."[181] But they had been clear about the limits of their assistance to this effort, emphasizing that, given India's resources and commitments, they could not take "supporting action" against Chinese aggression outside Indian territory.[182]

Indian concern about the nature of American efforts increased with US escalation in Vietnam in spring 1965, especially the aerial bombing campaign. Delhi believed that China was winning the propaganda war in the Afro-Asian world because of this escalation. In addition, India feared that the escalation would get in the way of détente between its two benefactors: the US and the Soviet Union. Moreover, the Indian government believed that Moscow could be part of the solution in Vietnam. American officials tried to convince Indian officials of the differences between US-Indian and Soviet interests in Vietnam.[183] Shastri, however,